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Dave Bennett

Dave Bennett is a multi-talented musician who pleases audiences by combining his skills as a clarinetist, pianist, guitarist, and vocalist. He embraces the best of multiple music genres.

Dave was interviewed via Zoom on April 16, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I am very pleased to have Dave Bennett with me this morning, not exactly musicians' hours. Hi, Dave.

DB: How are you doing, Monk? Good to see you.

MR: I'm going to — by way of introduction I was talking about how this archive project got started, but Joe Williams the singer helped us get it off the ground way back in 1995. And one of the things I have in the archive is this old *DownBeat* magazine.

DB: Okay.

MR: And there's this article, it says, "Is Joe Williams really Joe Williams?" And somehow I thought of you, because you do so many things in the music world. Who is Dave Bennett? Not getting too deep.

DB: Ah jeez, well I guess I'm still trying to figure that out myself. I'll let you know when I find out.

MR: That's the perfect answer. People who just may view this, and just a little background, you go everywhere from "Sweet Georgia Brown" to "Great Balls of Fire." And I'm curious if you — do you have an agent?

DB: Currently not really. Yeah I pretty much just answer the phone and thank God I work full time year-round. I've had agents and currently one for booking symphony pops, yes. But besides that it's been a period where I've been pretty much doing my own thing.

MR: Well the question I had in mind works either way. When someone calls you, do they ask for a specific thing you do, or do they say, "We'd like to book you" and do you have to say, "well which Dave Bennett do you want?"

DB: In essence, I mean I would say within the last three or four years the audiences that I play for aren't quite as purist in either direction you know. I'm finding that if I perform the shows where there's a variety of things in one show that seems to be the most powerful impact I've noticed. So for instance my quartet, which is what I tour with most of the time, I'm on clarinet probably sixty to seventy percent of the show. And then I'll pick up the guitar and play a few things that I've written, to kind of introduce them to my music, and then maybe throw in a Johnny Cash thing. And that'll get people curious. Okay what's coming next? So I found a way to make it flow within the different styles you

know. I mean I don't think things are too stylistically different that it would be too much of a change. But you know I'll start off the show — we usually open up with our version of "Eleanor Rigby" on the clarinet and it's kind of a — it's — we've kind of turned it into a jazzy, pop, funky thing. But it's not far out but it really has a nice groove to it. So that gets people drawn in. And then I'll do a few things of my own, and then keep mixing in new and old stuff. And then at the end of the show I'll go to the piano and close with "Whole Lotta Shakin' Goin' On" which just — it's a big party at the end. So it's a long-winded answer to your question but occasionally certain festivals might want just to hear the clarinet in which I say yeah, sure, of course you know. And I'll just do the straight ahead jazz. And then certain festivals might want more of a Americana roots thing and then I'll do all rockabilly. So it's all music that I love and I'm happy to do anything anybody would be willing to call me for. But it makes my life very rich, because I'm very fortunate that I can — I'm able to do these things and it makes me happy in the process.

MR: Well you had a parameter there you just mentioned, you get to do what you love. And it always strikes me there are certain songs under the big heading of Americana that just about touch everyone. I mean wouldn't you be shocked if you did a concert and you sang, "Goodness gracious" and nobody yelled "great balls of fire."

DB: That would be a strange feeling. I mean even with the differences of age that we play for, there are certain things that everybody knows you know. And so I like to keep that as part of the show, because it draws people in. It gives them something to remember, and they can relate to it.

MR: Do you think — you might not be able to answer this because you're not other jazz musicians, but do you feel that you pay more attention to the audience when you're improvising than the typical jazz musician who may be playing more for themselves?

DB: That's a good question. I don't know if I can compare myself in that mindset to other people because I don't know what they're thinking necessarily, but I know that for me personally I can feel the vibe of a crowd very quickly, you know whether they're with us or not. I mean my own personal taste, I don't really go for jazz that's really far out. That's just me. I mean as far as jazz goes I'm really drawn to swing and you know, Benny Goodman and Pete Fountain are my heroes and obviously a lot of the guys that you've talked to, Kenny Davern and all those. So I think I'm very conscious of where the audience is at. I mean you don't want to alienate anybody you know. It happens to be, I found in my own path that the crowd enjoys the same things that I enjoy, so it just happens to work out that we're all pretty much on the same playing field. There may be an occasion — I'd say fifteen years ago it was a little harder to play an old rockabilly tune for a jazz audience because there was more of a segregation and they didn't grow up with that music. You know the swing era folks maybe didn't — weren't on board with

the fifties thing. So it was a little harder, there was more ice to cut through then, so I just didn't do it as much for those crowds frankly. But now everybody seems to just enjoy a good song you know.

MR: What makes a good song?

DB: Oh boy. Boy if I have the answer to that —

MR: You'd write it.

DB: Yeah, that's a good question. I think what makes a good song for me is number one can somebody relate to it. It doesn't have to have lyrics, but if you're talking an instrumental, something that has a good pocket and a good groove, whether it's pop or jazz, and a melody that someone can walk away, you know like an earworm where they hear that melody and they can't get it out of their head. I think that's what makes a good song.

MR: You gave me a memory of — we used to go to the jazz parties to gather interviews and we went to one in Sarasota. This was probably in 1996. And a young Christian McBride was there.

DB: Oh wow.

MR: And you know this is the typical jazz party audience: retirees and, I mean they really know what they like. So at the end of Christian's set he played "I Feel Good" by James Brown.

DB: Oh did he really?

MR: Yes he did. He had a lot of nerve. And it kind of worked.

DB: Yeah.

MR: As you said, it's got that [scats] and everybody in their head's going [scats] even if they don't mean to.

DB: Sure. Well that's cool.

MR: Did you have any memorable moments, epiphanies or aha! moments as a kid that set you on this path?

DB: It was immediate. So — I began playing clarinet when I was ten years old in the fifth grade band. And I enjoyed swing music prior to that 'cause I like old movies. I used to watch Abbott and Costello and I heard the Andrews Sisters and that music, so I kind of had a predisposition for that era already. And then fifth grade came along and you can join the band if you wanted to. And my grandfather just said to me, "I think you'd have fun with a clarinet." Why he said that I don't know. I think it was just divine intervention. But my grandparents bought me a clarinet at the local pawn shop, figuring it might give me a hobby. They didn't know — nobody knew if I'd take to it or not. So they gave me the clarinet and at the same time they bought me a cassette tape of Benny Goodman just figuring that I'd get a kick out of this. And I don't know how, but I just knew at that moment that this is what I want to do for the rest of my life. And I didn't know if you

could or couldn't. I didn't know anything about the possibilities of a career failing or succeeding, I just knew that something really clicked. My life felt complete. And I learned a song by ear I think within the first week or two and I just moved my fingers around. I remember "I'll be With You in Apple Blossom Time," I just moved my fingers and I could play that melody. And so my teacher at the time, Jamie McLeod, who is a very dear friend of mine to this day, he was I think 26 and he played clarinet too, amazing clarinet player. And he got to meet Benny when Benny played at Hill Auditorium in Ann Arbor, Michigan, like a month or two before he passed away. So there was already that Goodman connection. And he was a great encouragement to me. So what I began doing was I'd play this cassette tape one microsecond at a time and try to play what I was hearing. And that's pretty much how I learned most of my things was by ear you know. My reading has always lagged behind. But my ear, I could hear things and play them. So that's how that early development came on. But yeah, I don't know, I was very young but my life had meaning at that point.

MR: That's saying a lot. Was there a point where you started to realize, you know you're learning these improvisations by ear? When did you connect to keys and form and relate what he was playing to chords?

DB: Chords came much later. But as far as knowing keys and form when I was 13 my dad saw an ad in the local paper and it said the Clarkston — Clarkston is a town right near where I live here. I live in Waterford, Michigan. And it said that the Clarkston Senior Center, they were having, every Tuesday, a jam session for anybody that wanted to come to play, one until four. So he took me over there and there was a group of old timers that would get together and jam every Tuesday. And I joined them every week. So when they would say let's do, I don't know, "Sentimental Journey" in the key of C. Well I didn't understand what that meant but then I figured it out for myself that, relative from concert pitch to B flat and I thought oh, okay, so that's what that means. So I would just listen very carefully and try to figure that out. Chords, that didn't really make much sense to me until probably my early twenties. I had a friend of mine that played piano for me, Tad Weed, who was an amazing jazz teacher too. So at that point I could play all these things by ear, I just didn't know what I was doing, really. And so I'd come to him and say, "What is this and why does it sound this way?" And he was able to go to the piano and show me and explain diminished, augmented, why I would play a certain run over a chord and why it sounded that way. And so I did things a bit in reverse. You know I could hear these things and play them I just didn't quite know what I was doing. So like you know right now I'm trying to get my reading back and my theory back, so I've been doing a deep dive into that. It tends to go away pretty quickly if you don't stay on top.

MR: I know what you mean. It's surprising after like oh my God it's been like twelve months since I actually sat in an ensemble and read a chart.

DB: Exactly. Yeah. So I'm guesting with a big band on Tuesday and we're doing three Gordon Goodwin charts, okay? And I haven't sat down to read a piece of music in quite a while so they handed me the charts and I looked at it and I thought yeah, I better start brushing up on this. So those have been my days and nights here.

MR: I love that phrase, because I've heard it from other interviewees, in that "I didn't really know what I was doing." In effect you did because your ear was telling you that it's okay.

DB: Right.

MR: And sometimes if you learn about these things beforehand they seem imposing. And I'm not sure I want to go there. So maybe playing by ear has a benefit to it.

DB: Probably. I mean it helped me you know. I mean even now I can look at a piece of music and it seems overwhelming when you see all the — what's there. But then once you play it I'm thinking oh, maybe it's not so bad after all. So maybe it's just getting past some of that fear and that overwhelming feeling you know. At least for me.

MR: Did your parents support your decision to be a career musician?

DB: Yeah. They were always behind me. To be safe and to hedge my bets I went to Oakland University and I actually got a bachelors and masters in accounting of all things. I never did it. I went through the schooling but you know I've been touring on the road since I was 14 so when I was in high school I would always talk to my teachers and say this is my situation can you work with me. And I would just take my books with me and — so it wasn't that I was gone consistently but I'd be gone on certain weekends and miss a Thursday, Friday, and a Monday here and there. But yeah, we talked about it when it was time for me to go to college and we just all agreed, if the worst should ever happen and I couldn't play music for one reason or another, or — I didn't really want to teach music, I didn't want to play in a symphony orchestra, so I thought what could I fall back on just in case, you know, this wasn't going to work out. And my uncle used to be CFO for the Detroit Lions. So I was thinking about something in business or economics and I remember, I think someone in the family said to me, "Well what about accounting?" I just said, "Okay, let's do that." I mean that's all the thought I put into it. So I went through nine years of college and toured extensively at that point in my twenties, and got both degrees, hung them on the wall and just kept on doing my thing. It's helped me in the business end because I do all my own budgeting, I do all the financial stuff myself, so I stay on top of it. But you know I'm very grateful that music is what I was meant to do you know.

MR: Well speaking of budgeting, do you remember how much money you made on your first paid gig?

DB: Yes. I was just out of the seventh grade. I was 13. And I began playing at a coffee house in downtown Pontiac, Michigan. My band director knew the manager and he would accompany me down there. I didn't have a band. So he had this computer program, Band in a Box you know, and you'd enter in the music and it would sound like a quartet playing behind you, so he cooked up about 30 or 40 tunes. And I would play there on weekends throughout the eighth grade. And yeah I remember I made $60 plus tips each time I played. And that was 1997 and it was really something.

MR: That's pretty good. Better than the $4 I made on my first gig.

DB: Yeah it was a really neat period. Because the neat thing at that point was that was 1997 and if you remember swing music came back in fashion. There were a lot of swing bands out there that were making it in the charts again. You had Big Bad Voodoo Daddy, Brian Setzer, Royal Crown Revue. So all of a sudden I saw these young people getting into this music that I had been into for the prior few years. And you know my classmates didn't quite get it, that I was into this older music, then all of a sudden they saw it in pop culture and I saw young folks that were into the same thing I was and that was really cool. Yeah.

MR: I was going to say, were you a bit of a — have some notoriety in school because of your talents?

DB: It was neat. You know I always say middle school is not generally the best period for most people, it's just weird. Yeah let's just get a bunch of people who have their hormones all over the place and put them in a building together. You know? It's just a bad idea. But yeah I would play for the school, either play the clarinet or I'd play the guitar and do an Elvis Presley tune or something, and that seemed to help me make friends. And then my friends at school would come out and see me play wherever I was playing. So yeah, it was a wonderful thing.

MR: If you went to a gathering, a cocktail party or something and you didn't really know anybody and you met a new person and they say, "Well what do you do for a living, Dave?" Do you have a short answer?

DB: I just say, "I'm a musician, a touring musician."

MR: Yeah. Have you ever had anybody say, "What's your real job then?"

DB: Yeah. Yeah. A lot of people would say that if they don't know. I mean I've been really blessed my entire life. I don't — blessing is the only way I could say it because on paper it makes no sense. I've been afforded great opportunities, you know, more than most. And I don't like to — if someone asks I'll talk about it but it's not something that I, you know, — so yeah people would say to me, "Is that your real job." I say, "Yeah, yeah. I've supported myself my whole life and just leave it at that. I mean you don't need to blow a trumpet and talk about your — at least for me you don't need to talk about yourself and do that whole thing.

MR: This process of figuring out what particular audiences are going to respond to, keeping yourself happy. Was there a progression to that? Did you have some misfires along the way of misreading an audience or —

DB: Oh yeah. Yeah. That's like a people skills type of thing, you know, where you read your crowd and you learn how to figure out where they're at. And there were times when I was younger where I might get a little over-ambitious and try something that was too much in left field to what they might be expecting. I remember the early days of me having a quartet where it was a traditional jazz audience and we did a swing version of "Pick Up The Pieces." And it didn't really work, you know. So you know how when you meet somebody, when you walk into a room and you can pick up on their vibe whether they're friendly or not or whether you can — I think most of us have that in us. But I think maybe you understand too, when you're a musician I think you're a little bit more sensitive than most. So you pick up on things very easily. And that's why at this point I think it's not hard to read a crowd. Because if you walk into a party and you meet one person you've got one vibe of that person you're picking up on. But if you walk in front of 2000 people, you've got 2000 vibes coming at you at once. I mean you can feel it. So I just kind of learned to go by that, and read it how it's going, and adjust to it you know. As again I say, everything that I would play for them is things that I enjoy playing so I don't feel I'm compromising anything, it's just people pay money, they hear you play, they want to be entertained. So do it, you know?

MR: Has anybody ever — this is obviously a silly question, but has anybody ever said, "Well you should try to act like Benny Goodman."

DB: No one's ever told me that I should. You know I've worn the same haircut since I was nine. I needed glasses when I was 10. So obviously that was Benny's look, but I think that when you have your heroes you pick up their mannerisms whether you realize it or not. You know and so you know there are a lot of the ways that Benny played or that he smiled when he played, I think that you just pick up on those things. Obviously also when I'm playing Jerry Lee's music or something there's things about him that obviously you just ingest. You know if you have people you look up to you learn from them in several ways. Were you referring to personality or —

MR: Yes I think so. I mean there's — the stories about him are — have been around forever. And everybody seems to have one. Every once in a while you talk to somebody like Bucky Pizzarelli never had an issue with Benny Goodman. He just liked him a lot and they got along swell.

DB: Yeah, well I've — I was on the road with Bucky for a little bit too, and Peter Appleyard, and I watched those interviews that you did with them years ago, and Bucky and Peter loved him. And I think one of the reasons they did, and because Benny is my hero, I've

read everything I could on him and read it a hundred times over, just 'cause it's an interest of mine. What I can gather about Benny was I think he probably felt he needed to protect himself from the world, and I think that aloofness that people talk about, I think he was totally aware of what he was doing, it was just a way to keep people out. But Peter and Bucky, from what I understand, probably put him at ease. You know? And I think that maybe Benny was able to let his guard down a little bit more and be open and be friendly with them. But we don't know what Benny was going through. I mean obviously I mean what a gifted guy and what a gift he gave to the world you know. But who knows what life was like through his eyes. You know I mean obviously I think with a genius personality like that you're — a lot of people have mood swings and you know you have your own demons. I mean we've all got our issues you know. So you get someone who's gifted like that I mean who knows what he was feeling.

MR: I have a piece of Benny Goodman memorabilia I thought I would share with you. This is from The Tonight Show —

DB: Oh. Is that Skitch Henderson?

MR: Yes. Skitch Henderson and Benny was the guest, and for some reason he requested Marian McPartland to play, and you've got the trumpet section in the back with Clark Terry and Snooky Young, Doc Severinsen, and Bob Rosengarden is the drummer and he's the one that gave us this photo.

DB: That is so cool. Hey you know I got a chance to play with Doc. I was twelve years old and it was in Greenwich Village. My mom's uncle, she had some family that lived in White Plains. And I remember there was this documentary that came out on Benny on PBS American Masters. And Doc was one of the people they interviewed. And so my uncle said that Doc was playing in Greenwich. And so they said, "Let's go out and see him." So I would never in a million years do this now, but when you're young you don't know, you know you don't know enough. So I just remember listening to this recording of Benny and Doc playing "Sweet Georgia Brown" on the trip out there. And I'm having dreams of playing with Doc. And we got to do it. He let me go up and play and we have it on video and everything, and he was so nice. He was so nice. And we had a ball. So that was a huge thrill. You know I got to play with some of Benny's old guys. I mean, you know —

MR: I've had a couple of experiences like that in this job, you know playing with Dick Hyman and just like pinching myself. It makes you play — not just better, but more wisely somehow.

DB: Well there are guys, you know they invented this stuff. You know just to be around them it's like being a sponge, you try to soak up everything you can.

MR: Did you ever feel like you were born in the wrong era?

DB: Maybe early on but now no. I think that whatever I'm meant to do, I've been placed here for a reason and for some reason all these different musical influences I have have made me who I'm trying to be now. And I don't think so. I think I'm probably where I'm supposed to be.

MR: I'm glad to hear that. Because there's not much sense in feeling that way. But you're also bringing the genuine music to a lot of people and sort of in your own way keeping it out there and alive.

DB: I'm trying to anyway, yeah.

MR: Yeah. I'm telling you, there's nothing like [knocks on desk] on the piano doing Jerry Lee Lewis. That is just like a joy.

DB: Well yeah, I remember I was twelve years old when I first heard his music. I bought this *Billboard* rock & roll set. It was 1957 through '61 and I mean for pure enjoyment the '50s is just — I love that era. I love the music, I love the styles and but yeah, "Whole Lotta Shakin'" and "Great Balls of Fire" were on there. And I just remember number one it made me happy. It was just such a great sound, a great groove, a great pocket. And it wasn't until my early twenties that I wanted to learn how to do that properly. I would dabble at a piano at school if they had one, and I could sound out a very elementary version of "Whole Lotta Shakin' Going On" but I was about 23 and I got the bug again and I thought you know I want to learn this. So I just grabbed all the recordings of his I could and learned it by ear you know and now I'm doing it more.

MR: Where do you write your original material? I mean do you sit with a guitar, piano, or do you think beforehand and get some lyric idea?

DB: All of the above. It just depends. There's been certain times where I've written a song on the guitar where I wrote the entire song including the melody and then wrote lyrics to it. Lyrics in general are not easy for me. You know some people are very gifted where they can whip them out cleverly very quickly, but that doesn't, that's not the case for me. I really have to take some time and be a wordsmith on it to really make it work. And there's been certain things that have just come out as I sang and played them. You know? I think we're always trying to find a formula to make it efficient and work, but it never seems to work that way. It's been a little while since I've written anything, and to be honest with you I've been avoiding it because it's like pulling teeth. I mean you sit there and you're trying to make something happen. And if you sit there for four or five days and nothing happens you just want to bang your head against the wall. But I've got to get back to it. It's been too long.

MR: Let's talk about eighth notes for a moment. I'm always fascinated, I've always been fascinated with the idea that for centuries eighth notes divided a note in equal parts. And then along comes the swing era and you have swing eighth notes, and then along comes

rock & roll and they go back to straight eighth notes. I don't have a question here it's just a subject that I really find fascinating.

DB: Well that is fascinating, because those early rock & roll records, if you listen to the drummers and the rhythm sections they weren't quite playing straight. It was not swing, not straight, but it was right in the middle you know. And I think they were just trying to figure out whatever this music was turning into. You know? But yeah totally. And then with some of the more modern jazz guys were guys that play the eighth notes behind the beat. You know? And then you've got the swing guys that were right, right there. And I guess over time you learn, your ear can decipher what's going on you know. It's a very good observation on that. I never — personally I like playing things on the beat. You know. I like that. That's what I love about swing. I mean those guys in the late '30s and '40s and they just — you could just — you don't even need the rhythm section really, the way those guys, they were so strong rhythmically you know. And that's an art in itself.

MR: Exactly. And I remember one of our folks talking about that. Like you have to be your own rhythm section. You have to have that feel and that drive within yourself and then match it with whatever you're surrounded with.

DB: I remember Dan Barrett telling me that when he was in Benny's last big band, that Benny would rehearse the band without the rhythm section you know. And he didn't want to hear any toes tapping either. You know like they had to have such an internal sense of swing and rhythm, and he said it was really scary because he was watching them and listening. But he understood what he was driving at and it was very effective. The band really learned how to drive forward and I thought that's — you know because Benny's gift of that rhythm I mean you could dance to his playing without a band it seemed like, he was so strong rhythmically. You know?

MR: You studied his career — why do you think he was dubbed "The King of Swing?"

DB: Boy. Well from my mind as far as being a clarinet player I don't think anybody played like him prior to him. You know that's number one. And I think he came along just at a time where that whole thing was meant to be. You know I mean he just had such an incredible band and it swung harder — in my estimation it swung harder than anybody else. That's just my opinion. It was tight, it was musically pristine yet loose, and it drove really hard. And I don't know it was just a winning formula. It was just probably by design, that was supposed to be his thing. And it just hit the world at the right time too with the Great Depression and everything, it gave everybody a sense of relief and joy. You know? That's the thing about his music. It makes you happy. You know I can still listen to his records and everything's okay.

MR: Everything's okay. I like that. It's interesting you said about how hard it swung because that photo I showed you with the Tonight Show band — Skitch Henderson was

responsible for that gathering. And years later — I'll make this brief — but years later he ran into Benny Goodman on — their tours came together. And Benny was talking about that night and he said, "Yeah, Skitch, but it didn't really swing." And here he had the cream of the crop. And I'm wondering if it had something to do with his instrumentation wasn't quite as large as some of the swing bands. And I wonder if he liked that — a little bit lighter, not ponderous, feeling.

DB: I saw that interview and that stuck out to me too. I think with Benny number one they said that with Benny he was not gifted verbally, at communicating things. You know he didn't have that ability to communicate properly probably what he was thinking. As far as it not swinging, maybe for Benny, his identity and his pinnacle of sound and swing was that band he had in the '30s. And I think that years later he was trying to get musicians that could play and sound like that with the same sort of approach to swing. And even though he had several bands that were just as talented and swung in a different way, I don't think it was the same as he remembered from the days where it was his thing. I remember reading something where in 1950, '51 where they re-released the — or they released the Carnegie Hall concert. So his idea was to get a band together again and re-record the old arrangements and go back on the road and kind of get that old thing going on. And it was great. And I forget where I read this but they said they were listening to a playback and Benny was sitting on the ground listening, and someone said to him, "Boy it sounds great, doesn't it?" And he said, "Yeah it sounds good," he said, "but it doesn't sound like THE band." You know? And I think it was just, there was a moment of glory he had that he wasn't able to get other guys to do the way that he wanted to. So I think when he said — I'm just assuming, I wasn't there you know obviously and I'm much younger. But from what I can gather about him I think there was a certain special period that he couldn't quite just get other musicians to do. So maybe he meant that it didn't swing the way that he would have wanted it to.

MR: When he had that amazing success, you know if what I've read is correct, at the Palomar Ballroom. And it's hard to separate your memory from something that is so consequential in your career. Like that was the moment, and we paid our dues to get there, so it carries a weight.

DB: I think I was reading where Lionel Hampton said that the days that he'd be playing with Benny, and it was when Charlie Christian was with the band. And those were my favorite recordings of his. I think it was just — he was on fire. And they said that Benny'd be playing and he was so happy you could see tears coming out of his eyes. You know? So again, here's this guy who's got this tremendous gift, but he wasn't able to communicate verbally very well what he was feeling, but it all came out in his music. So that had to have been something for him, because it was a special time. Apparently everything was

working just the way he wanted it to do. And the guys were playing the way that he would prefer it. And it was probably harder for him later on to find guys that could recapture that the way that he wanted it. You know? I don't know.

MR: I assume you watched "The Benny Goodman Story" with Steve Allen?

DB: Oh yeah.

MR: A few times?

DB: Oh yeah.

MR: Me too, and "The Glenn Miller Story." And I mean Glenn Miller's band, the LPs is what first got my attention as a kid I think. But you know that they're Hollywood-ized but they're fun nonetheless.

DB: Totally. I mean I'm a huge Glenn Miller fan. In fact I think Glenn was on my radar before I heard Benny. You know, so I love all that stuff. A lot of good memories.

MR: And are you aware of Sol Yaged?

DB: Yes. You know I got to meet Sol a few times. So back in 2010 I went to New York with my then-road manager, Hugh Lehl, he was a guy from Windsor. He used to put on jazz concerts. And he brought in guys like Bucky and Peter and Mundell Lowe, and so I got to meet these guys through him. So we went to New York just to visit and hang out, and I got to sit in with Sol where he was playing. So we spent an evening playing together. And then when I played Carnegie Hall in 2013 with the New York Pops, Bucky came up and guested with us and then Sol came to the show. So I got to see him that night. And then, you know like it was interesting watching him and Bucky talk because they knew each other from 60 years ago. And I saw the interview you did with Sol and he was totally the same way when I met him you know, just — he was a character.

MR: He was.

DB: But boy, he knew everybody and had a lot of stories, so that was cool.

MR: Yeah I remember that because he said, "You know I can play a song for every letter in the alphabet." And then he started to do it.

DB: Well okay, this is going to be a long interview.

MR: So the current music scene is very interesting in jazz. You have this amazing level of jazz in academia. At the same time you hear people bemoaning about the fact that there's not many jazz clubs and — are you involved in academia at all? Do you want to be?

DB: I am not currently involved. I don't know if I ever would be. If I were asked or if there was an opportunity for me to work in some capacity I don't think I would turn it down you know. I don't even know what would be involved in that, if you have to have a teaching certificate or what prep I would need to do to do something like that. I don't know. I really don't. Because I see the same thing you're seeing. I mean the music business is so weird now, compared to the way it used to be. And it's odd out there. I

mean I've been self-employed my whole life. And I'm grateful that financially I've done wonderful. But just because you've had success in the past doesn't mean that it's always going to happen. So there's moments I get scared and I wonder how is this going to keep going. But it always seems to. So, you know, as far as teaching goes, I would like to do that more. I've had an occasional student or lesson here and there. But I'd like to do more of that if I can.

MR: And does the theory of jazz playing play a role in the way you play? That was a lot of "plays." And by that I mean I remember you brought up Dan Barrett. And he had a funny thing to say about modes that a student had asked him about. I'm wondering if modes and the current jazz pedagogy has any role in what you do.

DB: I guess my honest answer is I'm not sure. I just kind of play things that speak to me, and I'm not quite sure what's going on right now as far as currently, like in jazz academia, or what current guys are playing. So I guess in that sense it really hasn't influenced me too much. For me personally, what I'm doing right now is I'm trying to develop more of my own ideas. And I think we're always trying to find ways to do that, to find our own voice. I remember — I got to meet Kenny Davern about a year before he passed. And I remember he was really big on — he was very friendly to me and he was really big on finding your own voice. And it's a hard — you're always trying to — okay well I get the idea of finding your own voice and your own ideas and like you talk about modes and the way you play what will give you your own distinct sound. But it's just trying to find how you do that you know. So what I found now is after a long time of listening to various different types of jazz or music and trying to learn things that maybe I don't like stylistically but it would help me to get my mind moving in a certain direction. For instance, learning things by musicians that play more far out even though it's hard for me to like that stuff it would help me as a player. But what I found now is you know guys like Benny and Pete Fountain and — I like their ideas the best. So what I'm doing is each day I'll learn, just for my own enjoyment, a new solo of one of them. From start to finish. And then from that point on I'll just start developing little ideas based on what I just learned them do. So I'm using that as kind of a template because I like what they're doing, I like the patterns, I like the harmonies, I like the drive. And I'll say okay, I see what they're doing here, now I'm just going to build something of my own off of something like this. And as a result of me doing that, which I started doing back in January I'd say, it's been as recent as that, it's re-ignited my love for this. Because I'm having more fun now. That's just my own little personal path — another step in finding my own personality as far as a player and — so now it's not as much work to practice, I'm enjoying it more. Because you've only got so much time on this earth and I might as well just do the things I want to do.

MR: You're very thoughtful about — are you a man of faith? Yes. And how does it help you in your day to day dealings?

DB: Well you know I think I've been a Christian since I was very young. I didn't understand it but looking back I think that the light bulb probably went off for me at an early age. Well number one I realized that I had been given a gift, which I'm very grateful for. It's not my own doing, you know, I received a gift. I work my hardest at it to cultivate it and do the best I can. And where this plays in for my own peace of mind is if I can keep my mind in that sense that what I'm doing is a service — not to sound pious or anything, I'm just being real. In a sense it's a ministry because if I can go out there and play for people and give them some joy then that's why we do this. So then it becomes less about me. Because I think anybody who's an artist or a musician, sometimes we get to grow too far inward, where we're looking at ourselves and gee I hope I can do this perfectly or I can keep improving, you know me, me, me. And that can be really defeating. So it's a good — I'm just trying to balance working really hard with all my might at this that I've been given, but this is apparently what I've been put on earth to do so if I can do that to the best of my ability then I'm happy. You know?

MR: You must run into some potentially aggravating situations on the road and with the different ensembles you find yourself working with. How do you deal with that?

DB: Fortunately there's rarely a bad situation I'm put in. If I'm working with different ensembles I've noticed I'd say 99.9 percent of the time I will know the people that I'm playing with. Rarely am I put in a position where I'll be dropped in with musicians that I don't know. And if I am, I've never really had a bad situation. You know there's been a couple things that have caused the sweat to run down my back. But you think okay, well, not much I can do about it. And if there's a situation that's really bad musically then I just look at the personalities I'm with and generally they're very kind people and you just encourage each other and you say hey, let's go out there and have some fun. Life is too short.

MR: Yes. And this gig will end.

DB: Yeah. I mean it's not the end of the world. I mean I can get just as uptight as anybody on the inside but you don't want to let those things come out because this may be the one time you're working with somebody and if they have this one memory of being with you for an hour or two, you want to leave them with something good. That's more important. Not easy, it's not easy, but it's important you know.

MR: You had a couple of Arbors recordings which I was happy to hear about. And that's a wonderful label and I'm so happy that they took an interest and you know Mat and — it was just a good service — speaking of service, they really provided a service for a lot of people.

DB: They — Mat was amazing, Rachel is amazing. I see her every year when we play at the Sun Coast Jazz Festival. And yeah, they were really, really great. I mean they did a lot of good for a lot of musicians and a lot of people. And yeah, those records I did for them were a great memory, especially the tribute to Benny that I did because I got to work with Dick Hyman and Bucky. I was fortunate, really fortunate to be kind of on that last wave to get to know these guys that were there for the original thing. And you know as a young guy for them to give me their stamp of approval gave me some confidence, I guess I'm doing okay. And I got to spent a lot of times talking with Bucky and Peter Appleyard, and just asking them stories and asking them what it was like. I wish I could do that all again with them, because now just being older and maybe a little bit more mature in some ways, there's certain other things I'd like to talk with them about and ask them about. Yeah I really treasure those things. They are really good memories.

MR: So I have an idea for your shows. I think you should introduce the Mozart Clarinet Concerto and see how that goes over.

DB: Oh, you know classical music for me is something that's scary.

MR: I agree.

DB: There's something about — and I've done a little bit, not much, but there are so many good classical clarinet players out there that do it really, really well. And I don't know there's something in classical music that I'm not getting or I just feel like there's so many people that can do it so much better than I could. Just let them do their thing and I can play to my strengths. But I don't know it's funny you should mention that because I just hooked back up with my first clarinet teacher. And I had a lesson with him last month and I'm going to have another one with him next month. And since he is such a master at classical music too and theory and reading, he's able to help me in a lot of areas that I haven't — I'm pretty rusty at. So just for my own curiosity he is taking me through some of the classical pieces. And one of them I want to work with him on is the Debussy "First Rhapsody" and that's a really challenging piece. And Benny did a great recording of it in 1940. I don't know if I'll ever have the guts to do it on stage. Maybe. I don't know. But you know I'm noticing in the last few weeks I've been looking at it, it has opened my ears to different things. Who knows? Maybe it'll spark a new creativity in me. I don't know. But yeah, I don't know classical music is something else. You've really got to have your ducks in a row to do it properly.

MR: And we get so used to taking liberties with our music. We're making it up a lot of times so it really takes a different kind of concentration I think, to stick to the page.

DB: Big time. I mean you talk about analytical and being right there, I mean that's a whole different skill set. You know? It's very challenging. But you know like we were talking about Benny you know he began classical lessons with Reginald Kell in 1950 and he

changed his embouchure, he changed a double lip embouchure and re-invented the way he did it. If you listen to his recordings between 1950 and 1958, he was using the double lip embouchure and if you compare that with the '40s, his style changed. It was much more pure, more, you know. And I always thought that he really didn't need anybody's help. You know? Because he was such a gifted player. He had that intangible thing that either you have it or you don't. You know? And he worked so hard to do that, probably in his mind properly. But I listened to him play the classical stuff in the late '30s and the '40s where he was just being him you know. And it's like this guy didn't need anybody's assistance. You know? It's like just do your thing you know. They should have been coming to him for help.

MR: I can almost see that moment, like some teacher telling Benny Goodman, "Well, you need to change your embouchure totally." Like come on.

DB: What are you out of your mind? Don't go there.

MR: Yes, maybe I'll be successful then.

DB: Yeah, yeah. You might make something of yourself. Jeez.

MR: Do you play the saxophone as well?

DB: I haven't touched a saxophone since high school. I used to play tenor in the jazz band. No, there's a lot of great sax players out there. I guess if I'm to play a different instrument I've always had more of an interest in doing the guitar or the piano besides the clarinet. There's a lot of killer doublers out there. I think — do you know Adrian Cunningham? Yeah, he's killer. I see him quite a bit on the festival circuit. He plays all the woodwinds. And as far as woodwinds go I'm pretty much stuck with the horn, the clarinet.

MR: Well it's another case to carry too. Who needs that?

DB: I know. I know, I've got this Gretsch guitar case and I had a flight case I had made for the guitar. And it's like you know I've got enough stuff.

MR: And I assume you get to take your clarinet with you, into your seat.

DB: Absolutely. I've got one of those cases that hold two, because something can go wrong with one and you've always got to have a back-up at least for my money.

MR: Well I admire you for your fashioning a career that is — I've heard people say, I mean you and I do a lot of the same things, and sometimes I've heard people tell me well I don't know what to expect when I go to one of your gigs. And as if that's not a good thing. Have you ever had anybody like question your versatility?

DB: Only if they've never heard us. You know. So there's been times where people will say, after the show they say, I guess it's a compliment, where they would say, "I heard this was a jazz concert." And they say, "I don't like jazz but I love what you guys did." Unfortunately I think nowadays the word "jazz" scares people away a lot of times,

because they have a preconceived idea of what they might be getting. Like to them maybe jazz is something really far out that they don't understand. Where just like rock, there are several different types. So that's an interesting thing I've noticed. But no, every time people after the show, they're always surprised in a good way. And you're just trying to lure them in you know.

MR: One word that I don't think is connected to jazz now enough is joy.

DB: Yeah.

MR: Like jazz is heavy and it's up here. And the fact that you spread joy, I think you just described it, when people say, "I don't like jazz but I liked what you did."

DB: Yeah I don't quite understand the — like that seriousness, you know, that darkness. Again everybody has their own approach to it. And if they want to be more serious about it that's their thing. But for me if you're up there performing for people, I think it should be more of a conversation. I remember hearing somebody say, "Well you know it's our job to educate the audience." And I was like, "Oh come on, lighten up, lighten up." For one thing that sounds really pompous. And second of all no, we're there to give them a break, to give them something to enjoy. And my own approach to things is when you're on stage, no matter where you are, make it more of a conversation. You know we're all in the same spot here you know and I think if you just approach it that way people can feel it. Because an audience can feel if you're distant or not, and I think they want to be able to connect with you. Why not? First of all it's a miracle that any of us can do this for a living. Right? And it's getting harder. It's getting harder. I mean there's not as many places to play as there was 30 years ago, so the fact that we're out there able to do this, let's squeeze every ounce of enjoyment and joy that we can out of this you know. At least that's the way I think about it.

MR: Do you have a preconceived or set amount of compensation that you're ready to negotiate to start with when you get a phone call? Because negotiating every single gig gets tiresome.

DB: Yeah I think there's different rates of compensation for different sorts of venues. You know I've had to raise prices just because of inflation and fortunately no one's had a problem with that. They're going to pay and yeah I would say so — I have different fees for different things. Like a performing arts center would be more because they have more of a budget. Private parties might be something depending on where it is and who it's for. And there are certain things that I probably wouldn't work below for. But then again if I have a free day and I want to do something for fun I'll take a little less just to go out and have some kicks you know. Hey you've got to be smart about it.

MR: Yeah. I remember the first couple times I heard gentlemen like Milt Hinton and Bucky and talking about the fact that they still played at weddings.

DB: Okay.

MR: You know I had this vision of — this unrealistic vision of what they do. Because they're your heroes, right? But they still, like a gig is a gig.

DB: Yeah I'm with you on that. I'm totally with you on that. I remember, I think it was in 1984 or 5 where Benny had laid off performing in public for a while because he had a heart operation. And he played at a friend of his daughter's wedding. And Bucky was on the gig. I mean that right there, Benny Good — you're going to hire Benny Goodman to play your daughter's wedding? Okay. Doesn't get any better than that. You know? So yeah I totally get that. But yeah, a gig is a gig and if it pays fair of course, yeah. I don't think you should be above anything if you feel that way, to do.

MR: Right. What's your very next gig, speaking of gigs?

DB: I'm playing Saturday, there's a place in Brighton, Michigan called — it's an Italian place called Ciao Amici's. And we're going to be doing two shows Saturday night, and that will be the full thing, you know, the jazz, the rock, the craziness. And then Monday I've got a private event duo performance with my piano player. Tuesday I'm guesting with the Mott Community College big band. Wednesday I'm playing at the Zehnder's Frankenmuth Ragtime Festival and then Thursday I'm off to Minneapolis to play four days with a friend of mine, Steve Pikal, he's a bass player and they're bringing me in to do some things. And then the month of May is a little lighter. The last four months have been heavy travel. So I figure in May maybe I'll try to sit down and get creative again and see what happens.

MR: Write some songs and work on the Mozart Clarinet Concerto.

DB: I have a funny feelings the songs actually might come before the Mozart.

MR: Well I've really enjoyed this conversation, Dave, and —

DB: Oh likewise. This has been great.

MR: I wish you the best and keep that craziness in there, as you mentioned.

DB: When is this going to be available?

MR: It'll be on our YouTube channel probably within oh ten days or so.

DB: Fantastic.

MR: Yeah we tran — my wife transcribes these and then we do editing if we need to but you didn't swear at all so I don't have to take anything out.

DB: No, no. Try to keep that to a minimum. No but when I — should I get to the New York area where you are I'll give you a ring.

MR: Please do. That would be a gas. All right I'll just pause this and we'll say our good-byes.

DB: Okay.